
Knowledge, skills and understanding

Content overview

Students will be expected to demonstrate and apply the knowledge, understanding and skills described in the content for each topic below. In addition, they will be expected to analyse, interpret and evaluate a range of scientific information, ideas and evidence using their knowledge, understanding and skills.

To demonstrate knowledge, students should be able to undertake a range of activities, including the ability to recall, describe and define, as appropriate. To demonstrate understanding, students should be able to explain ideas and use their knowledge to apply, analyse, interpret and evaluate, as appropriate.

Each topic begins with an overview of the wider biological context designed to encourage an overarching approach to both the teaching and learning of the subject. As such, it will not be directly assessed.

There are opportunities for students to develop mathematical skills throughout the content. They are required to apply the skills to relevant biology contexts. In order to be able to develop their skills, knowledge and understanding in science, students need to have been taught, and to have acquired competence in, the appropriate areas of mathematics relevant to the subject. These skills will be applied in the context of biology and will be developed throughout the course. All mathematical skills listed in *Appendix 6* must be assessed within the lifetime of the qualification.

Content that is common to the Pearson Edexcel Level 3 Advanced Subsidiary GCE in Biology B is in Topics 1-4.

Practical skills

Practical work is central to any study of biology. For this reason, the specification includes 16 core practical activities which form a thread linking theoretical knowledge and understanding to practical scenarios. In following this thread, students will build on practical skills learned at GCSE, becoming confident practical biologists, handling apparatus competently and safely. Using a variety of apparatus and techniques, they should be able to design and carry out both the core practical activities and their own investigations, collecting data which can be analysed and used to draw valid conclusions.

One important aspect of practical work is the ability to evaluate and manage potential risks. The variety of different practical techniques and scenarios in the core practical activities give students scope to consider risk management in different contexts.

Students should also consider the ethical issues presented by their work in the laboratory, which might include consideration for the ethical use of live subjects, the safe disposal of waste materials, and appropriate consideration for other people involved in their own work or who are working nearby.

Also central to the development of practical skills is the ability to communicate information and ideas through the use of appropriate terminology and ICT. Being able to communicate clearly the findings of practical work is arguably as important as the collection of accurate data.

In carrying out practical activities, students will be expected to use their knowledge and understanding to pose scientific questions which can be investigated through experimental activities. Such activities will enable students to collect data, analyse it for correlations and causal relationships, and to develop solutions to the questions posed.

Questions within written examination papers will aim to assess the knowledge and understanding that students gain while carrying out practical activities, within the context of the 16 core practical activities, as well as in novel practical scenarios. The written papers will test the skills of students in planning practical work – both in familiar and unfamiliar applications – including risk management and the selection of apparatus, with reasons. As part of data handling, students will be expected to use significant figures appropriately, to process data and to plot graphs. In analysing outcomes and drawing valid conclusions, students should critically consider methods and data, including assessing measurement uncertainties and errors.

Examination papers will also provide the opportunity for students to evaluate the wider role of the scientific community in validating new knowledge and the ways in which society as a whole uses science to inform decision making. Within this, they could be asked to consider the implications and applications of biology in terms of associated benefits and risks. Students may also be asked to evaluate methodology, evidence and data and resolve conflicting evidence.

Success in questions that indirectly assess practical skills within written papers will come more naturally to those candidates who have a solid foundation of laboratory practice and who, having carried them out, have a thorough understanding of practical techniques. Therefore, where possible, teachers should consider adding additional experiments to the core practical activities. The 16 core practicals will provide the basis from which some of the examination questions will be drawn.

Teachers should note that the completion of the 16 core practical activities can also provide evidence of competence for the Science Practical Endorsement (please see page 31) and that evidence must be provided for the 12 practical techniques listed in *Appendix 5c* through a minimum of 12 core practical activities.